

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	Medium

Question

Although science fiction was dominated mostly by white male authors when Octavia Butler, a Black woman, began writing, she did not view the genre as _____. Butler broke into the field with the publication of several short stories and her 1976 novel *Patternmaster*, and she later became the first science fiction writer to win a prestigious MacArthur Fellowship.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

Answer

- A. legitimate
- B. impenetrable
- C. compelling
- D. indecipherable

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the discussion of Octavia Butler’s career. In this context, “impenetrable” means impossible to enter. The text indicates that the field of science fiction was dominated by white males when Butler, a Black woman, started writing, but she published several science fiction short stories and a novel and later won a prestigious award; that is, Butler pursued science fiction writing and had success. This context suggests that Butler didn’t view the genre as impossible to enter.

Choice A is incorrect. In this context, “legitimate” would mean genuinely good or valid. Nothing in the text suggests that Butler didn’t think the science fiction genre was good or valid; in fact, it indicates that she pursued and made a successful career of publishing work in that field. Choice C is incorrect. In this context, “compelling” would mean attracting or demanding attention. The text indicates that Butler chose to write science fiction, so it wouldn’t make sense to say that she didn’t see the field as drawing her attention. Choice D is incorrect. To say that Butler didn’t consider science fiction “indecipherable,” or impossible to understand, would suggest that Butler did understand it. However, the text doesn’t address Butler’s ability to interpret works in the genre; rather, it focuses on Butler’s successful pursuit of writing science fiction.